his college to produce ‘self reliant, aggressive (in order to be progressive) men and women that new India wants’. [7] Here it was, as Bhagat Singh writes in ‘Why I Am an Atheist’ that,

> An incessant desire to study filled my heart. ‘Study more and more’, said I to myself so that I might be able to face the arguments of my opponents. ‘Study’ to support your point of view with convincing arguments. And I began to study in a serious manner. My previous beliefs and convictions underwent a radical change.

Bhagat Singh was also now in the heart of a city which had the province’s largest number of literate classes according to a 1920 Congress report. [8] Lahore was growing at such a pace that its population of 2,02,964 in 1901 more than doubled to 4,29,747 by the time Bhagat Singh was executed in 1931. [9] Bhagat Singh saw a place which was in fact ‘not one place but several’. [10]

In the 1920s, the city was already well acquainted with holding regular processions, beginning or ending at Mochi Bagh. Eminent figures from Lajpat Rai to Allama Iqbal to even Motilal Nehru addressed the rallies. Bradlaugh Hall, which opened with financial support from the Indian National Congress in the west of the old city in 1900, provided a venue that was especially constructed for political meetings. [11] Punjabi interest in the nationalist cause was in this way fully mobilized, and Bhagat Singh could not have failed to note this. In the last available letter written to his grandfather from Lahore on 14 November 1921, there lies buried amongst the felicitations to his elder relatives in Khatkar Kalan a reference to how ‘the railway people are planning to go on a strike’, about which Bhagat Singh adds, ‘one hopes that it would begin immediately after next week’. [12] Today, much of this history lies forgotten in ‘a city overwhelmed by nostalgia’ even though it was formerly a great regional centre. [13]

Bhagat Singh entered the National College in Lahore aged 14 in 1921. It was the first time that a student without a matriculation degree had been admitted for his undergraduate studies. The college was on the same site as the Tilak School of Politics, founded only the previous year in December 1920. It was to be a watershed moment in Bhagat Singh’s life, as he had the